

Figure 18: C. Subramania Bharati

As we saw, Bharati put much store by the Swadeshi shipping venture. A strong backer of VOC, he called him ‘Our Leader’, going to the extent of referring to him as ‘a *mahan*’ (‘a great soul’). Borrowing from Aurobindo, he had even called this swarthy, stocky Dravidian as ‘the foremost of Aryans’—this was his free translation of Aurobindo’s description of VOC as ‘the first complete example of an Aryan reborn’.[113] For Bharati, VOC was father to the Swadeshi company and the two steamers his adorable daughters. He had immortalized the heated exchange between VOC and Wynch in his poems.[114] As the references to this work show, his weekly *India* provides an ardent chronicle of the trials and tribulations of SSNCo. Deeply agitated by the crisis in the company, an idealist Bharati launched a fund through his weekly to support it. There was a personal dimension to his support as well. When Bharati was a young boy of ten, in 1892, his father Chinnaswamy Iyer had promoted an indigenous cotton ginning factory in Kovilpatti, not far from Tuticorin. But the factory collapsed leading to the death of his crestfallen father. Bharati blamed the British for this tragedy which upended his life. This experience must have weighed on him as SSNCo hurtled to a similar fate.